

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Hiring

Establish the Hiring Process

Foundations

- ☐ Confirm whether to adapt the existing process vs. rebuild
- ☐ Ensure every role includes a documented hiring loop
- ☐ Assign clear ownership (recruiter, hiring manager, approvers)

Infrastructure

- ☐ Implement a strong ATS (core coordination system)
- ☐ Maintain centralized hiring documentation
- ☐ Create visibility into approvals and exceptions

Interview Design

- ☐ Define clear interview problems/questions
- ☐ Create explicit scoring rubrics for each interview
- ☐ Standardize interview questions where appropriate
- ☐ Document full interview loops per role
- ☐ Train interviewers (shadow → reverse-shadow model)

Leveling Framework

- ☐ Define the written leveling framework
- ☐ Decide when leveling occurs (provisional + final)
- ☐ Establish a clear escalation path for leveling decisions
- ☐ Clarify who approves which levels

Job Descriptions

- ☐ Create a standardized job description template
- ☐ Maintain shared job description library
- ☐ Keep JDs aligned with the leveling framework

Avoid Over-Optimizing the Process

- ☐ Recruiters hiring $\geq$ ~5 engineers per quarter (if not headcount constrained)
- ☐ Interview loops are stable (not constantly changing)
- ☐ Time-to-offer $\leq$ 2 weeks from first interview
- ☐ Require a high bar before adding new steps/interviews
- ☐ Avoid unnecessary specialization or bespoke loops

Monitor & Debug the Process

Ongoing Oversight

- ☐ Include recruiting updates in the weekly leadership meeting
- ☐ Hold a monthly hiring review with the recruiting lead
- ☐ Maintain visibility into all hiring approvals
- ☐ Personally review out-of-band compensation requests

Metrics (Review Monthly)

- ☐ Hires per recruiter (throughput)
- ☐ Time to hire
- ☐ Offer rate
- ☐ Acceptance rate

Help Close Key Candidates

- ☐ Make yourself available for senior candidate sell calls

- ☐ Insert the executive sell step by default for senior roles (optional, not mandatory)
- ☐ Personally support strategically critical hires
- ☐ Avoid slowing process unnecessarily

Level Candidates Effectively

- ☐ Provisionally level early (phone screen + experience heuristic)
- ☐ Customize the interview loop based on the provisional level
- ☐ Final level based on holistic evaluation
- ☐ Define clear accountability for the final leveling decision
- ☐ Avoid committee overreach unless scale demands it

Standardize Compensation Decisions

- ☐ The recruiter calculates the offer using structured guidelines
- ☐ Approvers review leveling + compensation together
- ☐ Define approval rules for in-band vs. out-of-band offers
- ☐ Centralize compensation governance
- ☐ Avoid systematic overpaying to “win” candidates

Manage Hiring Prioritization

- ☐ Allocate recruiter bandwidth intentionally
- ☐ Align hiring priorities with the headcount plan
- ☐ Avoid reallocating recruiters to the weakest hiring managers
- ☐ Monitor recruiter-to-open-role ratio

Train Hiring Managers

Watch for these red flags:

- ☐ Unrealistic “unicorn” requirements
- ☐ Any interviewer can veto without accountability
- ☐ Constant push for non-standard compensation
- ☐ Indecisiveness → endless interviews
- ☐ Delayed engagement with strong candidates

Actions:

- ☐ Run targeted training sessions
- ☐ Set clear expectations for decision timelines
- ☐ Reinforce hiring manager accountability

Balance Internal, External & Network Hiring

- ☐ Track internal vs. external hires
- ☐ Avoid over-reliance on personal networks
- ☐ Avoid exclusively external senior hiring
- ☐ Ensure fair evaluation of internal candidates
- ☐ Periodically audit imbalance across teams

Improve Diversity Responsibly

- ☐ Track representation across hires, retention, and promotion
- ☐ Do not offload diversity accountability solely to recruiting
- ☐ Hold Engineering leadership accountable
- ☐ Monitor retention of diverse hires

Build Engineering Brand (If Needed)

- ☐ Assess whether brand investment is necessary
- ☐ Keep investment proportional to hiring needs
- ☐ Tie branding work to clear business outcomes

Consider Hiring Committees Carefully

- ☐ Clarify the accountability structure before introducing
- ☐ Evaluate tradeoff: consistency vs. speed
- ☐ Prevent diffusion of responsibility
- ☐ Use committees for calibration if needed — not as the default

Remember: The System Serves You

- ☐ Follow the process by default
- ☐ Break the process deliberately when necessary
- ☐ Weigh the cost of overriding vs. the cost of delay
- ☐ Continuously refine the system
- ☐ Ensure the system supports business outcomes

Executive Quick Diagnostic

If you can answer “yes” to these, your system is healthy:

- ☐ We can clearly explain our leveling framework.
- ☐ We know our monthly hiring metrics.
- ☐ Time-to-offer is fast and predictable.
- ☐ Hiring managers are accountable for decisions.
- ☐ Compensation decisions are consistent.
- ☐ We aren't over-relying on networks or committees.
- ☐ Our process feels intentional — not accidental.

